THE NEXT 100

POLITICS

Congress's New Hope

KANHAIYA KUMAR, 34

Congress leader in Bihar



BANDEEP SINGH

Kanhaiya Kumar's first electoral foray may have resulted in ignominious defeat against the BJP's Giriraj Singh, but it has done little to blunt the sharp edge of his oratory. It was this very skill that saw him fall foul of the BJP government at the Centre, which slapped sedition charges against him for allegedly shouting anti-national slogans on the occasion of Afzal Guru's third death anniversary in February 2016. A former president of the Jawaharlal Nehru University Students' Union, his joining the Communist Party of India was a logical progression. But the defeat at Begusarai in the 2019 Lok Sabha election and overtures from Congress saw him switch sides to the grand old party on September 28.

However, those who rushed to dismiss him as an opponent came not from the BJP but from RJD (Rashtriya Janata Dal), as its spokesperson said he did not know who Kanhaiya was. RJD may still be sitting pretty as the single-largest party in the Bihar assembly, but it will brook no challenge to its crown prince—Laloo's younger son and leader of Bihar opposition, Tejashwi Yadav.

Congress leaders, meanwhile, are pinning all their expectations on the charismatic new recruit, hoping he will revive their fortunes in Bihar, a state the party largely ruled till 1990. ■

– Amitabh Srivastava

WELL SPOKEN Kanhaiya won his first debate talking about Mother Teresa while studying at the Sunrise Public School in Begusarai. His prize? An English dictionary

"Educated, oratorical and now a pragmatic politician...Kanhaiya has all the ingredients to rise above others"

N.K. CHOUDHARY, *Ex-HoD, Economics, Patna University*